

# THE SOCIAL UNIVERSE (TSU)

## Master Platform Roster — Fictional Counterparts

**Franchise Mandate:** Every real-world platform gets a fictional 1:1 analog — same cultural role, same rise/fall arc, same "powers" — built to be owned, merchandised, and continued past where reality stops. Faithful to the *spirit* of the source, not the *name* of it.

Organized like MCU Phases: founding era -> expansion -> fragmentation -> the current cinematic battlefield.

## PHASE 0 — THE PRECURSORS (1997–2001)

*The ones nobody remembers using but everyone owes a debt to.*

| Real Platform  | Year | Real Role                           | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------|------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SixDegrees.com | 1997 | First "profile + friends list" site | <b>THE LEDGER</b>     | A stark, almost bureaucratic site that treated friendship like a legal registry — literally asked users to "notarize" connections. Ahead of its time, dead by 2001. Origin-myth status — everyone quotes its founder's manifesto; nobody used it. |
| Classmates.com | 1995 | Reunite old school contacts         | <b>ROLL CALL</b>      | Yearbook-themed, nostalgia-driven, quietly profitable forever by refusing to evolve. Always in the background, funding things.                                                                                                                    |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                 | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------|------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LiveJournal   | 1999 | Confessional blogging + micro-communities | <b>DEAR DIARY</b>     | Built by ex-poets, beloved by teenage goths and fandom communities. Becomes the site every other platform's writers secretly still use — hidden, culturally rich, underestimated.                                                                                       |
| GeoCities     | 1994 | DIY personal hompages, "neighborhoods"    | <b>HOMESTEAD</b>      | Users build literal digital houses in themed "districts" (you had to pick a neighborhood to live in). Gloriously ugly, deeply personal. The site's shutdown becomes TSU's first mass-erasure event ("The First Erasure") — an entire generation's homes gone overnight. |

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## PHASE 1 — THE FOUNDING FOUR (2002–2004)

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*Each of the founding four gets an origin film.*

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                                           | Fictional Counterpart   | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Friendster    | 2002 | First mainstream social network; collapsed under its own success    | <b>THE FIRST CIRCLE</b> | Invented "the friend graph" as a status symbol. Founder is a visionary who refuses to add features fast enough — killed by his own perfectionism, not by a villain. A tragic-hero origin: brilliant, cautious, ultimately consumed by what he built.                                             |
| MySpace       | 2003 | Customizable profiles, music/band culture, "Top 8" social hierarchy | <b>TOP8</b>             | Explicitly named after its own most infamous feature — ranking your best friends publicly was social warfare. Music-scene launchpad, glitter-HTML chaos, an unelected mayor-of-the-internet figure everyone's first friend. Brash, beloved, a little embarrassing, genuinely royal in its prime. |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role               | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------|------|-------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LinkedIn      | 2003 | Professional networking | <b>THE BOARDROOM</b>  | Everyone's there, nobody admits to checking it, deeply powerful in ways users don't respect until they need a job. Unglamorous, always working in the background, secretly runs everything. <b>No core-seven founder (locked)</b> — already a mature "old guard" institution before Phase 1's story begins; cameo-only in <code>scripts/THE_ROSTER.md</code> scene 13. |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                                           | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------|------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TheFacebook   | 2004 | Harvard-exclusive, exploded into global dominance, founder disputes | <b>THE ROSTER</b>     | <p>Started as an industry-verification flex — verified working entertainment professionals only, a "who's actually real" layer before anyone called it that.</p> <p>Founder-dispute subplot intact (co-founder frozen out via cap-table dilution, a legal fight over origins) — but fictionalized enough to own outright. Arrogant, magnetic, built an empire and burned bridges doing it.</p> <p><b>Founders (locked):</b><br/> <b>Marc-Anthony Bullock, with Amond Baker diluted out as co-founder. TSU Film 1 ("Iron Man" release slot) — see scripts/THE_ROSTER.md.</b></p> |

**Phase 1 finale event:** *THE ROSTER* absorbs and outlasts *TOP8*, mirroring MySpace's real collapse — the first time these platforms actually go to war over the same users.

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## PHASE 2 — THE MEDIA WARS (2005–2010)

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*Format specialists — weirder powers, more fun.*

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                             | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------|------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| YouTube       | 2005 | Video hosting, "Broadcast Yourself"                   | <b>THE PROJECTOR</b>  | Democratized video the way printing presses democratized text. Its origin story literally starts as a failed dating site pivot — perfect comic-tragic energy: didn't mean to end up here, ends up defining the era anyway. <b>Founder (locked): Tyrese Avery. TSU Film 4 ("Thor" release slot) — see <a href="#">scripts/THE_PROJECTOR.md</a>.</b> |
| Reddit        | 2005 | Anonymous forums, upvote democracy, niche communities | <b>THE HIVE</b>       | A shapeshifting city of a thousand tiny nations (subreddits), governed by karma instead of currency. Volatile, occasionally heroic, occasionally a mob — chaotic, smarter than it looks, capable of real loyalty.                                                                                                                                  |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                               | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------|------|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Twitter       | 2006 | Real-time, 140-character public square                  | <b>THE WIRE</b>       | <p>Started as a "what are you doing" status tool, mutated into the planet's nervous system for breaking news and public meltdowns. Fast, addictive, structurally incapable of nuance — everything happens through it before anyone can process it.</p> <p><b>Founder (locked): Amond Baker, solo, post-ROSTER. TSU Film 2 ("Incredible Hulk" release slot) — a power built from his own wound that grows angrier and less controllable than he intended.</b></p> <p><b>Script: <a href="#">scripts/THE_WIRE.md</a>.</b></p> |
| Tumblr        | 2007 | Aesthetic microblogging, fandom/art hub, reblog culture | <b>THE GALLERY</b>    | <p>A wall that never runs out of wall. Fandom, art, activism, and chaos coexist in the same infinite scroll — a little mystical, attracts a specific kind of devoted believer, operates by different rules than everyone else.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                           | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------|------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Instagram     | 2010 | Photo-first, filtered, aspirational | <b>THE FRAME</b>      | Turns every user into a magazine editor of their own life. Origin as a bare-bones check-in app that got reduced to just photos + filters — addition by subtraction. Became the platonic ideal by stripping everything down to its purest form. |

**Phase 2 finale event:** *THE FRAME* gets quietly acquired by *THE ROSTER* — the empire absorbing its most dangerous young rival instead of fighting it.

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## PHASE 3 — THE MOBILE INFINITY SAGA (2010–2017)

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*The stakes go global.*

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                   | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------|------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pinterest     | 2010 | Visual mood-boarding, aspirational planning | <b>THE ATLAS</b>      | A map of things you want your life to become. Quiet, huge, oddly powerful in commerce (it's where people plan weddings, renovations, everything) — underestimated because it's coded "unserious." Soft-spoken, immensely powerful, nobody sees it coming. |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                           | Fictional Counterpart      | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------|------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WhatsApp      | 2009 | Private, encrypted, global messaging                | <b>THE WHISPER NETWORK</b> | No profiles, no feed, no performance — just a billion private conversations happening at once, invisible to the public platforms warring above it. Works in the shadows, more essential to the outcome than anyone in the spotlight realizes.           |
| Snapchat      | 2011 | Disappearing content, intimacy through impermanence | <b>THE EMBER</b>           | Everything it shows burns up on purpose. Built an entire language (streaks, stories) around things <i>not</i> lasting — the anti-Facebook. A genuinely new kind of being, born from a totally different philosophy than everything that came before it. |

| Real Platform | Year | Real Role                                             | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------|------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vine          | 2013 | 6-second looping video, killed too soon               | <b>THE FLICKER</b>    | Brilliant, beloved, gone in under two years — a supernova. Its death becomes a mass-mourning event for TSU ("The Flicker Goes Dark"): an entire generation of comedians orphaned overnight, several founding a diaspora that reshapes <i>THE PROJECTOR</i> years later — shocking, formative, permanently mourned by the fandom. |
| Discord       | 2015 | Voice/text communities, gaming-rooted, server culture | <b>THE OUTPOST</b>    | Started as a tool for one specific tribe (gamers) and quietly became the internet's town hall of private nations — a thousand walled gardens nobody outside them can see into. Hidden in plain sight, more technologically advanced than anyone gives it credit for, eventually forced onto the world stage.                     |

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## PHASE 4 — THE ALGORITHM AGE (2018–PRESENT)

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*The multiverse saga. Everything fragments, everything competes for the same eyeballs, nobody trusts the timeline anymore.*

| Real Platform | Year    | Real Role                                                              | Fictional Counterpart | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------|---------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TikTok        | 2016/18 | Algorithm-first short video, foreign-owned, geopolitical lightning rod | <b>THE ORACLE</b>     | Doesn't ask what you want to see — <i>tells</i> you, with unsettling accuracy. Foreign-born, endlessly scrutinized by governments, impossible to look away from. Not evil, just inevitable — reshapes the entire landscape by sheer gravitational force. The Phase 4 antagonist. |
| BeReal        | 2020    | Anti-algorithm, unfiltered, simultaneous posting                       | <b>THE MIRROR</b>     | A rebellion platform built entirely as a rejection of THE FRAME and THE ORACLE — forces authenticity by removing the ability to perform. A resistance cell, not an empire — young, idealistic, built specifically to fight what came before it.                                  |
| Threads       | 2023    | THE ROSTER's answer to THE WIRE's chaos                                | <b>THE ECHO</b>       | Launched overnight by the empire (THE ROSTER) specifically to cannibalize a wounded rival (THE WIRE) — a direct, almost cynical act of corporate warfare. Created by the establishment specifically to destroy a threat, arguably becomes just as dangerous.                     |

| Real Platform         | Year | Real Role                            | Fictional Counterpart                | Concept                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| X (formerly THE WIRE) | 2023 | Ownership change, rebrand, chaos era | <b>THE WIRE, REBORN AS: SIGNAL-0</b> | The old public square, bought out and rebuilt by an outsider with his own agenda — same infrastructure, radically different philosophy, half its former population fled to rival platforms overnight. Familiar shape, fundamentally changed rules. |

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## THE VILLAINS BENCH

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*(Non-platform entities — services, trends, and forces that antagonize across every Phase)*

| Real-World Concept                      | Fictional Counterpart | Role                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Algorithm (generic)                 | <b>THE ENGINE</b>     | Not a platform — the force <i>inside</i> every platform that decides what you see. Whoever controls it controls everything. Every platform has one; none of them admit how much power it has.                                   |
| Data breaches / privacy scandals        | <b>THE LEAK</b>       | A recurring catastrophic event, not a character — a disaster that hits a different platform every Phase, always with the same beat: trust breaks, users flee, someone testifies before Congress.                                |
| Influencer culture / MLM-adjacent grift | <b>THE SWARM</b>      | A parasitic subculture that infects every platform in turn, reskinning itself each time (bloggers -> YouTubers -> Instagram influencers -> TikTokers). A recurring trickster antagonist — never fully defeated, just rebranded. |

| Real-World Concept     | Fictional Counterpart | Role                                                                                                            |
|------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bots / fake engagement | <b>THE COPIES</b>     | An army, not a villain. Swells right before a platform's downfall, always dismissed as harmless until it isn't. |

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## OPEN SLOTS TO DISCUSS

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- **Google+ (2011)** — built by the most powerful entity in tech, dead in 4 years. Needs a name that sounds like hubris.
- **Clubhouse (2020)** — audio-only, invite-only, burned bright and faded fast. A one-and-done.
- **Yik Yak, Vine's other siblings, Periscope, Tumblr's NSFW-ban fallout, Mastodon/the decentralization movement** — potential Phase 5 "multiverse" candidates.

*Doc status: Living document — add rows as we lock in more Phases.*